

THIRD EYE | SHANKAR AIYAR

Band-Aid Economics

Every crisis brings in its wake a clutch of opportunities. Great minds think of new ideas while the mediocre get bogged down in discussing the crisis. Sure, eventually the meek may inherit the earth but it is unlikely that the mediocre will rule it. In the eight months since the global meltdown, China has restructured its forex reserve deployment, invested billions in tonnes of commodities to last the next boom cycle, charted out a green power strategy and is buying land in the Americas and Africa to create strategic food reserves. Just one more instance: by 2030, China will have a billion people living in cities. To cope with it, China plans to build 50,000 high-rise buildings and 170 mass transit rail and subway systems. In Shanghai, they are building an offshore wind farm to fuel the city's energy needs.

Even as you read past the punctuation you can hear the murmurs. The handy alibi India hides behind is a self-righteous "Oh, but they don't have democracy". Truth be told, it is 'incrementalism' that has held India back. Incrementalism is the reigning ideology; nay, incrementalism is the religion. Every budget—and I say this because that seems to be the only time governments display some ambition—Indians are subjected to incremental ideas that deliver homeopathic doses of development.

Look at the Five-Year Plans. India's famous Five-Year Plans are riddled with incremental ideas, poor ambition and punctuated by missed targets. Even the Eleventh Plan document finds critical problems framed between the dire "unless" warnings and convenient escape routes lined with "ifs" and "buts". Each year four lakh

students appear in entrance exams for a shot at the 2,400 IIT seats. Yet our target for creating new IITs is in single digits. Why should we have only six or seven AIIMS-like hospitals? Is the trillion-dollar economy so beggarly? Why not 100 super hospitals? Why not insure all those living below the poverty line through a budgetary allocation, use the money as seed capital, partner with insurance companies, ask state governments to part with land for equity

and auction the licences for medical colleges to private players to bid and manage? We could do with a robust crop insurance system to beat the phantom of drought, but the idea is still a pilot project. Pilot projects, task forces, missions, councils, committees... these are all inventions of the 'incrementalists'.

It is a good idea to have 100-day programmes but what India really needs is a 100-year perspective and ambition. UPA II has the minds and the mandate to make this happen. Every challenge—be it providing education to children across the country or improving infrastructure to deliver power or water to millions—is an opportunity to create new benchmarks. It is time we said "yes we can". We may not be able to achieve all the targets but the least Indians deserve is ambition they can be proud of. India can no longer afford band-aid economics.



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DIED: Sarod maestro Ustad Ali Akbar Khan, 87, one of the few musicians who took Indian classical music to the



West. He had been nominated for five Grammy Awards.

ISSUED: By a special court, non-bailable warrants against Jamaat-ud-Dawa chief Hafeez Mohammad Sayeed, operational chief of Lashkar-e-Toiba Zaki-ur-Rehman Lakhvi and 20 others for the 26/11 Mumbai attacks.

REJECTED: By Pakistan's Supreme Court, Sarabjit Singh's mercy plea. The court upheld the death sentence given to him for his alleged involvement in bomb attacks in Pakistan in 1990.

CREATED: By Sandeep Sejwal, a national record in the 50 m breaststroke event, clocking 28.77 sec at the Paris Open Swimming Championships.

